

Canadian Business Grant Application Checklist

General preparation guide for federal and provincial SME grants. RTM advisors prepare applications — this checklist is not a self-serve submission tool.

RTM GLOBAL CANADA · GROW · CONNECT · SUCCEED
Business Grants & Funding Guide

www.rtmbusinessdirectory.com/grants
Tel: +1 416 900 8728
640 Sentinel Road, North York, ON M3J 0B2

About this document: This free checklist covers *general* document and process preparation used across many Canadian programs. A **personalized program shortlist** matched to your business comes with the **Maple Checklist** advisor package or your member **Funding Workspace** after you build your **RTM Grant Profile**.

How RTM fits your grant journey

1

Build your RTM Grant Profile

Join RTM at membership.rtmbusinessdirectory.com (\$100/year). Active members use profile-based matching on the Funding Workspace — not generic search alone.

2

See matched programs

On grants.rtmbusinessdirectory.com, review profile-matched federal, provincial, and sector programs with eligibility notes and deadlines.

3

Choose an advisor package

Request Maple Checklist through Northern Star on www.rtmbusinessdirectory.com/grants. RTM grant advisors prepare narratives and submissions — you are not applying alone.

Grants marketing hub (packages, flyer, free checklist request)

<https://www.rtmbusinessdirectory.com/grants>

Member Funding Workspace (after signup + active membership)

<https://grants.rtmbusinessdirectory.com>

Join RTM membership

<https://membership.rtmbusinessdirectory.com>

Step 1 — Confirm your business eligibility

Registered Canadian business

Your business must be legally registered in Canada (federal or provincial incorporation, or sole proprietorship with a CRA business number).

Tip: Have your Business Number (BN) from CRA ready — it is required on almost every application.

Operating in an eligible province or territory

Most federal grants are Canada-wide. Provincial programs (e.g. Ontario, BC, Alberta) require you to operate and employ within that province.

In operation for required minimum time

Many programs require 1–2 years of operating history. Some startup grants accept businesses under 12 months. Check each program's eligibility window.

Tip: Startup? Look for IRAP, BDC, and Ontario Starter Company Plus — these are often startup-friendly.

Annual revenue within program range

Grant programs often define SME thresholds: under \$10M, under \$50M, or fewer than 500 employees. Confirm your revenue band matches.

Not majority government-owned or publicly listed

Most SME grants exclude Crown corporations, publicly traded companies, and non-profits (unless the program is specifically for non-profits).

Step 2 — Gather your core documents

CRA Business Number (BN) and GST/HST registration

Required for almost every federal and most provincial applications. Download from your CRA My Business Account.

Certificate of incorporation or business registration

Federal programs need your articles of incorporation. Provincial programs accept provincial registration certificates.

Tip: Keep both the original and a notarized copy accessible.

Two most recent years of financial statements

Income statement, balance sheet, and cash flow. Audited preferred; accountant-prepared accepted for most SME programs.

Tip: No financials yet? Bank statements plus a CPA-signed summary may be accepted for smaller programs.

Most recent CRA Notice of Assessment (NOA)

Personal NOA for sole proprietors. Corporate T2 return for incorporated businesses.

Business plan or project description (1–3 pages)

Describes what your business does, what you plan to use the grant for, and expected outcomes. RTM grant advisors help prepare this for paid packages.

Tip: Be specific about jobs created, revenue impact, or innovation outcomes — reviewers spend only a few minutes per application.

Proof of Canadian citizenship or permanent residency (if applicable)

Required for programs targeting immigrant entrepreneurs, women-owned businesses, Indigenous-owned businesses, and similar streams.

Payroll records or employee count documentation

WSIB clearance certificate and payroll summary for programs tied to job creation or training.

Step 3 — Identify the right programs for your business

Review federal programs (ISED, NRC-IRAP, CanExport, CDAP)

ISED and NRC-IRAP are major federal SME funding sources. CanExport targets export-ready businesses. Verify whether CDAP or successor programs are open for your sector.

Tip: Program status changes often — confirm current intake before investing weeks in an application.

Review your provincial program

Ontario: Ontario Innovation Tax Credit, Starter Company Plus, Scale-Up Vouchers. BC: BCTECH Fund, Innovate BC. Alberta: Alberta Innovates.

Check municipal and regional programs

Many municipalities (Toronto, Ottawa, Calgary) run small business grant pools through economic development offices.

Tip: Toronto Starter Company Plus is delivered through partner organizations — applications open on a fixed cycle.

Sector-specific and equity-focused streams

Agri-food, clean tech, women-led, Black-owned, and immigrant entrepreneur streams are often less crowded. After you join RTM, profile-based matching via your **RTM Grant Profile** on the **Funding Workspace** (members at grants.rtmbusinessdirectory.com) highlights programs aligned to your industry, location, and ownership — not a generic one-size list.

Confirm open intake periods and deadlines

Many programs use fixed intake windows (quarterly or annually). Missing a deadline can mean waiting 3–12 months for the next cycle.

Step 4 — Prepare and submit your application

Complete the online application form in full

Do not leave fields blank. Use “N/A” where a section does not apply. Incomplete applications are often rejected without review.

Write a clear project narrative

Answer: What is the project? What problem does it solve? How will grant funds be used? What are measurable outcomes?

Tip: Lead with your strongest outcome in the first paragraph.

Prepare a detailed budget breakdown

Line-item salaries, equipment, contractors, marketing, etc. Must match the program’s eligible expense categories.

Tip: Ineligible expenses (e.g. rent or owner salary in some programs) can reduce approval or disqualify the application.

Attach all required supporting documents

Cross-reference the program checklist against your Step 2 documents. Upload PDFs with clear file names.

Review and submit before the deadline

Allow at least 48 hours before the deadline for portal issues. Government sites often slow near closing dates.

Keep a copy of the submitted application

Save confirmation numbers and a PDF of what you submitted for follow-up and post-award reporting.

Tip: RTM advisors review your full application before submission as part of the **True North Standard** package and above.

Step 5 — After submission: track, follow up, and report

Log reference number and expected decision date

Timelines range from about 4 weeks (municipal) to 6 months (federal).

Respond promptly to requests for additional information

Officers may request clarification within 2–4 weeks. Slow responses can disqualify you.

If approved: sign the funding agreement carefully

Agreements specify eligible expenses, reporting, repayment, and IP terms. RTM advisors review agreements for clients on processing packages.

If declined: request written feedback

Use feedback to strengthen your next submission.

Submit post-award reports on time

Late reports can trigger clawbacks and affect future eligibility.

Typical independent grant consultants charge about \$4,000+ for full application support. RTM list prices are roughly 50% of that market rate; active RTM members (\$100/year) receive an additional 50% off list on advisor packages below.

RTM advisor packages

RTM membership — \$100/year unlocks member package pricing and access to the Funding Workspace at grants.rtmbusinessdirectory.com. List prices apply until membership is active.

Package	Member price (CAD)	List price (CAD)	What you get
Maple Checklist	\$149	\$299	Eligibility scan, top programs for your profile, 30-minute RTM grant advisor call
True North Standard	\$1,000	\$2,000	One full grant intake, narrative draft, submission support
Provincial Bridge	\$1,600	\$3,200	True North Standard plus one provincial program (ON, BC, AB, etc.)
Northern Star	\$3,250	\$6,500	Up to 3 applications within 12 months, priority RTM grant advisor

Ready for a personalized shortlist? Request Maple Checklist or join RTM and open your Funding Workspace.
Marketing hub: www.rtmbusinessdirectory.com/grants · Membership: membership.rtmbusinessdirectory.com · Workspace: grants.rtmbusinessdirectory.com

Important: Programs, deadlines, and amounts change frequently. Verify current status at Canada.ca/grants-contributions or with an RTM grant advisor before investing significant time in an application.

■ PROUDLY CANADIAN

RTM Business Directory · Grant Advisory

info@rtmbusinessdirectory.com · +1 416 900 8728 · 640 Sentinel Road, North York, ON M3J 0B2

© RTM Global Canada · rtmbusinessdirectory.com/grants